Copy the clippers who win on Upwork

Short answer: in October 2026, the short-form video editors winning on Upwork are mostly Top Rated editors from Pakistan, Vietnam, Bangladesh, the Philippines and Nigeria. They list **low hourly rates (median $19.99/hr, range $5–$34)** but earn **$40K to $1M+** through hundreds of small **fixed-price, per-video jobs ($15–$540)** plus one or two big retainers. Their profiles share one formula. The title contains the exact words clients search ("Short-Form Video Editor") plus platforms or a niche. The overview opens with a client problem or a free-sample offer. All 20 skill slots are filled with Upwork's own platform tags. The portfolio shows vertical clips with clear titles and before/after covers. The best-paid editors are **specialists** (podcast clips, UGC/Meta ads, talking-head creators, one industry), not generalists. Live jobs from October 19–27, 2026 ask for **hooks, burned-in captions, fast turnaround and long-form-to-short repurposing**. About **1 in 4 jobs offers a paid test**, and about 1 in 4 names AI video tools. New Nigerian editors are breaking in right now with **$5–$30 test jobs inside one narrow niche**. Isaac T. (Lagos, no badge) ranks #1 in Nigeria for "short form video editor" with 40 small sports-editing jobs. Farida U. (Lagos, account about September 2026) won $133 and $260 contracts within about 5 weeks. For Harry, the evidence points to one plan. Use the title phrase "Short-Form Video Editor" with **podcast and talking-head clips** as the niche. Build 6–8 honest spec samples. Keep **$18/hr** as the profile rate but quote **small fixed prices** for first tests. Apply within hours to paid-test jobs that have few proposals.

How to read this report. All profile and job data comes from a live, read-only Upwork pull on **October 27, 2026**. Numbers inside freelancers' own overviews (views, brands, "Top 3%") are **their claims and are not verified**. Lines marked **Inference** are analysis, not observed fact. Job links use the format `https://www.upwork.com/jobs/~02<ID>`.

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1. Twenty-five top editors earn big with small rates

What the top profiles look like

These are real profiles from the October 27 pull. "TR+" = Top Rated Plus. "TR" = Top Rated. "Jobs" = total jobs on the profile.

Editor	Country	Exact title	Rate	Earned	Badge	Jobs
Reid N.	USA	Short Form Video Editor | Ads That Actually Convert	$30	$100K+	TR+	351
Khoa Nguyen B.	Vietnam	Video Editor (YouTube, Instagram Reels, Short-Form)	$16	$100K+	TR+	479
Serhii K.	Ukraine	Short-Form Video Editor | Ads, Meta Reels, UGC	$28	$100K+	TR+	166
Syed Muhammad A.	Pakistan	Short-Form Video Editor | UGC Ads | VSL | Reels & TikTok | Get Sales	$19.99	not shown	TR+	318

Editor	Country	Exact title	Rate	Earned	Badge	Jobs
Shams Y.	Pakistan	Short-Form Video Editor | High-Retention Reels, TikTok & Shorts	$15	$40K+	TR+	98
Hafsa H.	Pakistan	YouTube Video Editor | Reels, Shorts & Motion Graphics	$5	$70K+	TR+	508
Fahad T.	Pakistan	Podcast Video Editor | YouTube Podcast Specialist	$27	$200K+	TR+	253
MD A.	Bangladesh	Podcast Video Editor | Talking Head, YouTube, Shorts & Social Clips	$15	$100K+	TR	146
Hammad H.	Pakistan	Real Estate & Contractors Video Editor | Reels, VSLs & Podcast	$15	$100K+	TR+	361
Abdullah D.	Pakistan	Talking-Head Video Editor | YouTube, VSL & Reels | Motion Graphics	$30	$50K+	TR	360
Val M.	Philippines	Senior AI Video Editor | UGC & DTC Ads That Convert (TikTok & Meta Ad)	$29.99	$100K+	TR+	98
Yevhen B.	Canada	Video Editor | YouTube, TikTok, IG Reels & AI Video	$34	$1M+	TR+	1,499
Anu F.	Nigeria (Ogun)	Video Editor & AI Filmmaker | YouTube, Podcasts & AI Video	$15	$50K+	TR+	196
Ayomide O.	Nigeria (Lagos)	Performance Video Editor | Paid Ads, Short-Form & YouTube Content	$20	$50K+	TR+	82
Paula E.	Nigeria (Abuja)	Short-Form Video Editor | Reels, TikTok & Youtube Shorts, Talking-Head	$15	$10K+	TR+	13

Across all 25 established profiles pulled, **21 were Top Rated Plus**. The **median rate was $19.99/hr**, and **about 72% of their jobs were fixed-price** (6,705 fixed vs 2,632 hourly). Almost all were busy: most had 3–10 new contracts started in October 2026.

What this means: the top editors do not win with high hourly rates. They win with **many small per-video jobs**, then keep a few clients for months. Raheel A. (profile) earned **$23,704.78 from one hourly contract** (1,566 hours). Ayomide O. earned **$6,233** on one "Short-Form Video Editor - Reels/TikTok/Shorts for Established Health Creator (800K+)" job. Paula E. earned **$10,135** from one fixed contract, "Short Form Video Editor for Boutique Hotel & Restaurant" (Paula).

Nigerian proof: three Lagos-area paths

Being Nigerian is not a barrier. Three Nigerians hold Top Rated Plus in this niche (Anu F., Ayomide O., Paula E.). Paula's history is the most useful for Harry because it shows a newcomer path:

Date	Contract	Amount
Mar 2025	Newsletter and advertising design	$35
Aug 2025	Social Media Management	$250

Date	Contract	Amount
Oct 2025	Short Form Video Editor for Boutique Hotel & Restaurant	**$10,135**
Dec 2025 – Aug 2026	Several small "Video Editor for Social Media" jobs	$40–$200
Aug 2026	Video Editor for Social Media	$900

She did this with **only 13 jobs, 9 skills and no video intro** (Paula). Her portfolio uses one clear naming style, "Short-Form Video Editing | Med Spa" or "Short-Form Video Editing | Talking Head Video for Dominique".

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2. New Nigerians break in with $5–$30 tests in one niche

These are newer or smaller profiles. They are closer to Harry's situation. "RT" = Rising Talent.

Editor	Place	Exact title	Rate	Earned / jobs	Badge	How they started
Isaac T.	Lagos	YouTube Sports Video Editor | NBA, NFL, Shorts & Reels	$10	$1K+ / 40	none	Tiny fixed jobs ($10–$80), sports only. Ranks **#1** on 5 Nigeria searches
Farida U.	Lagos	Short form Video Editor for social media	$10	$300+ / 2	RT	Account about Sep 2026. $133 and $260 jobs within about 5 weeks. Won after a client test video
Kehinde A.	Osun	Short-Form Video Editor & Clipper | TikTok, Reels & YouTube Shorts	$5	$20+ / 4	RT	First clips $10 + $10 + $5 in Oct 2026, streamer clipping niche
Hassan H.	Kwara	YouTube & Short-Form Video Editor | Faceless Content Specialist	$15	$8K+ / 11	TR	$15 first job → $240 → $140 → $360 → **$6,050** contract about 11 months after joining
Emmanuel O.	Lagos	Short-Form Video Editor | Personal Brands & E-commerce	$25	$10K+ / 14	TR+	$265 trial video → hourly **$8,429.94** on a "100 Videos/Month" TikTok job
Kazeem M.	Lagos	Video Editor | Short-Form, UGC & Meta/TikTok Video Ads	$15	$4K+ / 27	none	$10 jobs with strong reviews, then $790 and $1,230 contracts
Ejiofor J.	Ogun	AI UGC Ad | AI Video Ad | TikTok, Meta & Product Video	$17	$3K+ / 23	TR	Many $4–$15 jobs; Top Rated within about 5 months
Oubaid B.	Tunisia	Short-Form Video Editor | Meta Ads, Dental Clinics & Podcast Reels	$10	$400+ / 6	RT	$15 test → $30 → $75 → $120 → $160 from a repeat client in about 11 weeks
Dua D.	Pakistan	Short-Form Video Editor for TikTok, Instagram Reels & YouTube Shorts	$20	$2K+ / 21	RT	20 contracts in about 2 months at $10–$30. **#1 in global Rising Talent search**

(Account dates are estimates decoded from profile IDs. They are approximate.)

The pattern is very clear. Almost every newcomer started with a **ladder of tiny fixed jobs ($5–$30)**, often called "test" or "trial". Each one closed in 1–2 days with a 5-star review. Then the same client hired them again, or a bigger hourly job came. Reviews praise **speed, responsiveness, following direction, hooks, captions and "clean cuts"** much more than fancy effects. Kehinde's review says: "Kehinde found great hooks herself and the captions + cuts are super clean" (Kehinde).

Rates in Nigeria: Nigerian short-form editors list **$5–$28/hr**, mostly **$10–$15**. Successful Nigerian Top Rated editors list **$15–$25**. **Harry's $18 is above the newcomer middle (about $10) but inside the winners' range.** Very low rates did not help: the $5 accounts earned between $20+ and $4K+ (Chinenyenwa E. worked 784 hours for $2,352.50, about **$3/hr**).

Inference: the profile rate matters less than the first fixed-price quotes. Kazeem lists $15 but took $10 tests. Ejiofor lists $17 but took $5–$15 jobs. Harry can keep $18 and do the same.

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3. How winners build each part of the profile

Title: use the exact search words

In the 25 top titles, the words used most often were:

Word in title	How many of 25
"Video Editor"	24
"Reels"	13
"YouTube"	13
Ads / Meta / DTC / performance	11
"Short-form"	10
"TikTok"	9
"Shorts"	8
"UGC"	8
"AI"	7
"Podcast"	5
"CapCut", "Premiere", "viral", "captions"	**0**

Most titles use a **"Role | Platforms | Niche or result"** pipe formula and are **64–70 characters long** (14 of 25). Tools go in skills, not in the title.

Search ranking depends heavily on the title. No profile in the 200 search results was paid-boosted. Profiles with the **exact search phrase in the title** ranked high even with almost no history. Tatheer A. ("Short Form Video Editor | YouTube Shorts, Reels & TikTok Editor", **1 job, $2K+, no**

badge) ranked **#8** for "short form video editor" and appeared in 5 different searches. Meanwhile Yevhen ($1M+) ranked only #25 for "TikTok video editor". In Nigeria, **Isaac T. ranks #1 with no badge** in five searches. **Inference:** for a new profile, an exact keyword title is the strongest free ranking tool. The badge and JSS still help a lot overall.

Web guides agree. Pick one niche, put it in a 70–80 character title, and avoid a "mush" title that lists many tools (GigRadar; LevelUp Upwork). Since **May 28, 2026** Upwork allows only **one profile** (Specialized Profiles were removed). Upwork's AI recruiter **Uma** now builds shortlists for clients by reading your profile (UpAlerts). So one clear profile with all your keywords matters more than before.

Overview: the first 250 characters must sell

Upwork shows only about the **first 250 characters** in search results (LevelUp Upwork). Top editors open with one of four hooks:

Hook type	Real example (exact words)	Who
Client pain question	"Your video looks great. So why isn't anyone buying?"	Ammad R.
Free sample	"Get a FREE 20 second podcast teaser to experience my editing quality before committing."	Fahad T.
Free sample	"Not sure if I'm the right fit? Send me a raw clip, and I'll turn it into a 30 second, high retention video edit."	Shamima K.
Plain niche promise	"I help podcasters and creators turn raw recordings into clean, engaging video podcasts and high-retention short clips for YouTube and social media."	MD A.
Stats stack	"🏆 Top Rated Plus - Top 3% Talent on Upwork / ⏱️ 2200+ hours worked..."	Shams Y.

7 of the 25 top editors put a **free or low-cost sample offer** near the top. After the hook, the body usually follows this order: services → proof (named clients, views) → **process** → tools → call to action ("Click the 'Invite to Job' button"). Shams describes his process like this: "You send raw footage and 1-2 reference videos... First draft usually within 48 hours... 2 rounds of revisions included." Many top editors end with a **keyword block** for Upwork matching. Syed even titles his "Keywords for UMA and Client Matching". Both emoji-heavy and plain styles appear among $50K–$200K earners.

Inference: Harry cannot copy the stats or the brand names, because he has none yet. He *can* copy the **pain hook, the free-sample offer, the clear process and the keyword block**.

Skills: fill every slot with Upwork's own tags

Most common skills across the 25 top profiles:

Skill tag	Count of 25
Video Editing	25

Skill tag	Count of 25
Adobe Premiere Pro	20
Video Post-Editing	18
Motion Graphics / Adobe After Effects / Instagram Reels / YouTube Shorts	17 each
Video Editing & Production	16
TikTok Video	14
Social Media Video	12
Short Video Ad / Video Production / YouTube Video	11 each
Podcast Editing / Color Grading	9 each
CapCut	6

14 of 25 used all 20 slots. Clients' skill filters match **exact Upwork skill names**, so free-text skills are weaker. Put your main niche skills **first**. Fahad, the $200K+ podcast editor, lists Podcast Editing, Podcast Content, Social Media Video and Instagram Reels first (Fahad).

Portfolio: trust work for a profile with no reviews

Strong portfolios use:

- **Keyword titles**, e.g. "UGC Video Ad | TikTok & Reels Editing | Adobe Premiere Pro" (Serhii).
- **Results in the title** when real, e.g. "23M Views Viral TikTok Clip | Podcast Short-Form Editing" (MD A.).
- **Before/after covers**. Christopher G.'s cover shows "BEFORE / AFTER... ATTENTION GRABBING CAPTIONS" (Christopher), and newcomer Dua D. uses before/after thumbnails (Dua).
- **"Style of" labels**, e.g. "Video editing in the style of Alex Hormozi" (Serhii) or "Iman Gadzhi Style Video Editing" (Syed).
- **Honest test stories**. Emmanuel O. labels one piece "This was one of the trial reels i edited that got me a full time role" (Emmanuel).

Size does not decide success: Reid has **1 item** and $100K+, Fahad has 6 and $200K+. Web guides suggest **5–7 niche samples**, each with a one-line note about the goal and the edit choice (Fueler). With no clients, re-cut public footage and **label it clearly as spec work** (Fueler). For podcast clipping, the owner's permission is needed unless the show runs an open clipping campaign (Open Clip).

Pricing and catalog: per-video prices rule

What	Real figures
Top editors' listed rates	$5–$34/hr, median $19.99
Recent short-form fixed jobs	$15, $20, $25, $30, $40, $48, $50, $60, $70, $80, $90, $120, $130, $150; larger $425–$1,050

What	Real figures
Paid tests seen	$15 "Trial video - 1", $110 trial ad, $200 "Paid Test", $208 "TEST VIDEO", $400 trial episode, $475 "Paid Tryout"
Paid consultations	11 of 25 offer one, from $10 to $150
Package in overview	Nawwal I.: "8 Reels a month, $240 / 16 Reels $440 / 24 Reels $600" (Nawwal)

The Upwork tool did **not show Project Catalog listings or prices** for any profile, so catalog packages could not be checked. Web guides say a catalog listing has its own title and search surface, and suggest 1–2 small fixed offers as easy entry points (GigRadar; LevelUp Upwork). Blog price guides ($50–$200 per short video) are **much higher** than what live Upwork jobs pay (Grey). Trust the live data.

Price-led messages ("lower price than others, with an unlimited number of revisions", "best discounts on bulk work") appear only among low-rate generalists such as Rahool T. (profile).

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4. Specialists earn more than generalists

The 25 top profiles fall into three groups:

Group	Examples	Typical result
Volume generalists	Rahool T. ($10, 1,218 jobs), Hafsa H. ($5, 508 jobs), Yevhen B. ($34, $1M+ over 14 years)	Huge job counts, cheap jobs
Short-form generalists	Shams Y., Vo N., Shamima K., Paula E.	Steady $25–$150 jobs
Specialists	**Ads/UGC:** Reid, Serhii, Val, Ammad, Ayomide. **Podcast:** Fahad ($200K+), MD A. **Talking-head:** Abdullah. **Industry:** Hammad (real estate & contractors)	Higher rates ($19–$30) and the biggest contracts: Ayomide $6,233, Fahad $2,400, Val $1,050, Ammad $650

Newcomers show the same thing. The fastest risers name a buyer or niche: sports (Isaac), dental clinics (Oubaid), wellness brands (Nawwal), book authors (Denis N., Top Rated within about a year). Meanwhile the generic "Short-Form Video Editor | TikTok, Instagram Reels & YouTube Shorts" title is **crowded**: 7 of the top 25 global Rising Talent titles use it. **AI UGC / AI avatar ads** is the fastest-growing sub-niche. About 13 of 25 Nigerian Rising Talent titles lead with "AI Video Creator" or "AI UGC", so it is getting crowded in Nigeria too.

Web sources also call **podcast clipping** and **UGC/paid-ad editing** the best-paid short-form niches, because businesses pay for them and they lead to monthly work (OpenClip; Motionbox).

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5. Live jobs ask for hooks, captions and moment-picking

A sample of **46 short-form jobs posted October 19–27, 2026** shows what clients want right now. (Percentages come from this sample only, not all of Upwork.)

Who is hiring

Niche	Share of 46 jobs
E-commerce / DTC / UGC ads (incl. AI UGC)	24%
Creator / personal brand (talking-head, vlog, fitness)	22%
Podcast and interview clipping	22%
Agencies (white-label editing)	13%
Brand content	9%
Faceless	4%

Clients are **37% US-based**. **35% have no spend history**, meaning they are new clients. Levels: **11% entry, 52% intermediate, 37% expert**. **8 of the 9 jobs checked in detail set no Job Success Score, earnings or hours minimum**, so having no badge does not block Harry. Competition does: **32% of jobs had 20–50 proposals**, mostly within 48 hours.

What the job posts ask for

Client request	About how many of 46 jobs
Captions / subtitles (burned-in, word-by-word)	~27
Premiere Pro named	~29
"Hook(s)"	~22
CapCut named (some *require* it)	~22
Fast turnaround (24–72 h)	~11
AI tools (Higgsfield, Kling, Veo, Seedance, ElevenLabs)	~11
Paid test or trial	~11
"Start your proposal with word X"	~10
Long-term / ongoing	~30

The main workflow is repurposing long videos into shorts. One brief says "Cut 8–12 vertical clips" per 35–60 minute podcast (job 2114857437752065733). Clients increasingly want the **editor to choose the best moments**: "We are hiring your taste" (job 2113171568100173763). Another asks: "how do you decide which 45 seconds of a 20-minute conversation to pull?" (job 2114930969374718293).

There are two style camps. One wants high-energy edits: "punch-ins and zooms, dynamic captions, and sound effects" (job 2114829953564348724). The other wants clean edits: "no emoji rain, no zoom-punch on every sentence" (job 2114930969374718293). The clean camp is mostly podcast, medical and B2B clients. **Inference:** a newcomer can show good judgment in a clean 30-second clip without expensive plugins.

Clients are split on AI. One says "Please don't run my footage through AI clipping tools like Opus Clip... I can tell" (job 2114828747055955653). Others require Higgsfield, Kling or Seedance (job 2114980102668226868). Upwork itself reports **AI video generation & editing as its fastest-growing AI skill (+329% year over year)** (Upwork).

What clients pay

Pay type	Real figures
Posted hourly ranges	Mostly $10–$20/hr (lowest $3–10, highest $15–30)
Per clip, very low	$2.50 (2 clips for $5), $3.33–$5 (8–12 clips for $40)
Per clip, normal	$8–10, $10, $16, $25, ≈$33, $40
Per clip, premium	Up to ~$120 per podcast clip (up to $240 for 2 clips, job 2113171568100173763)
Full-time	"$2,000 to $3,000/mo base + $1,000 to $1,500 per winning ad" (job 2114597756622623634)

The middle per-clip price was about **$13**. Most fell between **$8 and $40**.

Good first targets for a newcomer

Job	Why it suits a newcomer
CapCut template Reels, Germany, $8–12/hr (job 2114627606931454969)	"Simple, template-based work. No motion graphics"; no JSS required
Interview → clean Reels, US, $85 test (job 2114930969374718293)	"One link is enough... not how many effects you know"
B2B interview clips, Netherlands, $65K spent (job 2115036671707838703)	Raw footage attached: "the serious ones will cut a few seconds of it in their proposal". A sample beats reviews
Paid tests (11 jobs), e.g. "paid test: one episode, 4 clips"	A paid test lowers the client's risk of hiring someone new

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6. Red flags to avoid

Bad jobs

Red flag	Real example
Tiny pay for real work	"$5 fixed price" for 2 podcast clips with animated captions in 24 h (job 2113725844115924075)
"Expert, full-time" for $5	Faceless channel manager + editor, $5 budget; client's 61 contracts total $536 (job 2115063163419432666)
Salary under $3/hr	"$500 per month" for "40 hours per week" (job 2115006012071022900)

Red flag	Real example
Unlimited revisions	"A willingness to work on unlimited revisions is essential" (job 2114922701210851358)
Unpaid test	"IMPORTANT – UNPAID CREATIVE TEST" (job 2115047397432237917)
Off-platform contact	"all communication and file transfer happens on WhatsApp" (job 2114829953564348724)
Bad client rating	Rated 2.0 by freelancers (job 2114806442347069125)
Test-abuse complaint in client reviews	A past freelancer: "asked for 6 shorts to be edited. 1 short is enough for a test video" (job 2114962787293732701)

About **1 in 5** postings showed a clear red flag. **Inference:** leaving Upwork's messages or payments probably removes payment protection. (Upwork's policy text itself was not checked in this research.)

Bad profile habits (seen on new Nigerian profiles)

Habit	Example	Result seen
Dozens of fake-looking jobs in "Employment" with big brand names	Elizabeth P.: McKinsey, Vice Media, Kellogg, Calm (profile)	$1K+ but **JSS 77**
Fake degree	Olamide A.: "Master of Divinity" at "Google Cloud Skills Boost" (profile)	$200+, 3 jobs
A "review" in the overview with no real feedback	Chioma U.: quotes a 5★ review but has 0 feedback (profile)	1 job
Keyword dump instead of an overview	Daniel A.: 70+ check-mark lines, about 100 invented agencies (profile)	$700+ after 35 jobs (about $20 per job)
Suspicious $5 jobs closed in 1–3 days	Nawwal I.: five $5 contracts; one long review copies her overview's words (profile)	Unclear
Off-niche portfolio items	Chinenyenwa E.: "Data entry for research" in a video portfolio	$3/hr effective

Padded profiles still win some small jobs. But the **clean, niche, proof-based profiles hold the big contracts** (Paula $10K+, Emmanuel O. $10K+, Hassan $8K+). **Inference:** fake employers, fake reviews or self-paid $5 contracts risk an account ban. Harry should do none of them.

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7. Harry's step-by-step plan

This plan copies what the data shows works. The sample text below is **a suggestion for Harry**, not a real profile.

Step 1 — Choose one niche (Day 1)

Main niche: podcast and talking-head clips (long video → 30–60 second vertical clips). Reasons from the data:

- Podcast + creator/talking-head work = **about 44%** of live jobs.
- Many paid tests ("one episode, 4 clips").
- Clients want **judgment** (picking moments, clean captions), which a beginner can show without costly plugins.
- It leads to weekly, ongoing work (4–6 clips/week, 8 videos/month).
- Top podcast specialists earn well (Fahad $200K+, MD A. $100K+).

Second lane (in an "Also available for" section, not the title): UGC / short ad edits. This is 24% of jobs, but it needs ad skills (hooks, variations, aspect ratios) and is crowded with "AI UGC" titles in Nigeria.

Step 2 — Write the title (Day 1)

Sample title (63 characters):

> Short-Form Video Editor | Podcast Clips, Reels, TikTok & Shorts

Why: it starts with the exact search phrase "Short-Form Video Editor" and adds the four words clients search most (podcast clips, Reels, TikTok, Shorts). There are no tool names in the title.

Option B (68 characters): "Short-Form Video Editor | Podcast Clips & Talking-Head Reels, Shorts"

Step 3 — Write the overview opening (Day 1–2)

Sample opening (first 250 characters do the selling):

> Your podcast has great moments, but nobody sees them. I turn long episodes and talking-head videos into 30–60 second vertical clips for TikTok, Reels and YouTube Shorts, with a strong hook in the first 3 seconds and clean, word-by-word captions.
>
> Not sure yet? Send me one raw clip. I will edit a short free sample so you can see my work before you hire me.

Then add these sections, in this order:

1. **What I edit:** podcast clips, interview clips, talking-head Reels, simple product/UGC ads.
2. **How I work:** "You send the episode and 1–2 reference videos you like → I pick the best moments (or use your timestamps) → first draft within 48 hours → 2 rounds of revisions included → 9:16 export (1:1 or 16:9 on request) + editable project files."

3. **Tools:** list only tools Harry really uses (for example CapCut desktop, Premiere Pro, Descript). Say AI tools are used for speed, with human checking.
4. **Working hours:** Lagos time (WAT) overlaps UK/EU business hours and US East mornings. State your hours and reply time. (Inference: a cheap trust signal; not measured.)
5. **Also available for:** UGC ad edits, hook variations, faceless clips (this keeps those keywords searchable).
6. **Call to action:** "Click 'Invite to Job' and send one raw clip."

Do not write view counts, brand names or reviews until they are real.

Step 4 — Add 20 skills in this order (Day 2)

All of these are tags used by the winning profiles above. Check the skill editor: one Upwork help page says 15 slots and another says 20 (LevelUp Upwork). Only add tools you can really use.

#	Skill	#	Skill
1	Short Video	11	Adobe Premiere Pro
2	Podcast Editing	12	Subtitles
3	Instagram Reels	13	Content Editing
4	YouTube Shorts	14	Video Post-Editing
5	TikTok Video	15	Short Video Ad
6	Social Media Video	16	UGC
7	Video Editing	17	Motion Graphics
8	Podcast Content	18	YouTube Video
9	CapCut	19	Video Editing & Production
10	Social Media Content Creation	20	AI Video Generation

Step 5 — Build 6–8 honest samples (Days 2–7)

Sample	Source	Title style to copy
3 podcast clips (clean style)	Public podcast with permission, or a friend's podcast	"Podcast Clip
1 podcast clip (high-energy style)	Same episode, different style	"High-Energy Podcast Clip
1 before/after	Raw vs. final side by side	"Before vs After
1 talking-head Reel	Harry's own footage or a friend's	"Talking-Head Reel for Coaches
1 simple UGC ad, 9:16 + 1:1	Royalty-free or own product footage	"UGC Product Ad

Rules from the data and guides:

- Use vertical **9:16** and a cover frame with a big caption or a before/after.
- Add 2–4 lines per item: the goal, the hook choice, caption style, pacing.
- **Label spec work as spec.** Never claim client results for it.
- Post the clips on your own TikTok/Shorts account. Real view numbers can come later.
- Add a 60-second **video intro**. Most fast-rising newcomers have one (Isaac, Kazeem, Kehinde, Oubaid, Dua).

Step 6 — Set prices (Day 7)

Item	Suggested setting	Data it is based on
Profile hourly rate	**Keep $18/hr**	Nigerian Top Rated range $15–$25
First 3–5 jobs	Fixed **$10–$30 per clip** or small test	Newcomer ladders: Oubaid $15 → $160, Kazeem $10 tests
After 3–5 five-star reviews	$25–$40 per clip, or batch prices	Normal per-clip range $8–$40
Monthly package (in overview or a Project Catalog listing)	e.g. "8 clips/month" and "16 clips/month"	Nawwal's $240 / $440 / $600 model
Never	Unlimited revisions, under $5 per clip	Red-flag list

(**Inference:** these are suggested prices built from the observed ranges, not prices any one editor uses. Project Catalog data was not visible.)

Step 7 — Apply smart (Week 2 onward)

Job filter. Apply only if most of these are true:

- [ ] Short-form podcast, interview or talking-head clips (or simple CapCut Reels)
- [ ] Payment verified
- [ ] Under 15 proposals, ideally posted in the last few hours
- [ ] Paid test, or a clear per-clip price of $8 or more
- [ ] No unpaid test, no unlimited revisions, no WhatsApp-only contact
- [ ] Client rating 4.5+ or a new client with a clear brief

Connects cost **8–17 per job** in this sample. Freelancers get 10 free Connects a month and extra Connects cost **$0.15 each** (goLance). So choose carefully.

Proposal shape (short):

1. First line: copy their platform and deliverable. For example: "I can cut your 35–60 min episodes into 8–12 vertical clips with clean captions." **Use their start word** if the post asks for one (about 1 in 5 jobs do, e.g. "HOOK").
2. **One link** to your closest-matching sample, not a showreel. Clients ask for 2–5 links "not a showreel montage".
3. One sentence on how you pick moments (many briefs ask this directly).

4. Offer a small **paid test** (one clip) and give a per-clip price.
5. If raw footage is attached, **edit a few seconds and include it** (job 2115036671707838703).

Short, specific proposals that name the platform and deliverable in the first sentence are the standard advice (AiProposer).

Step 8 — Deliver fast, then grow (Weeks 2–12)

- Deliver tests **within 24–48 hours**. Reviews in this niche praise speed and following direction.
- After each good test, offer a weekly batch ("4–6 clips per week").
- Raise per-clip prices after 3–5 five-star reviews.
- Keep all messages and files on Upwork.
- Payouts: from September 1, 2026 Upwork reportedly charges **$2.99 per Direct-to-US-Bank withdrawal** for non-US freelancers, so withdraw monthly, not weekly (Cleva). Nigerian freelancers often use USD accounts such as Cleva, Grey or Raenest (Techeconomy).
- Rising Talent has **no JSS requirement**. It needs a 100% complete profile, recent activity and good early performance (Upwork Help). Farida U. ranked **#2** in the Africa Rising Talent search about 5 weeks after joining.

Conclusion

The biggest lesson is that **in this niche, rank and first jobs come from fit, not fame**. A one-job editor with the exact title phrase ranked above a $1M+ editor, and a no-badge Lagos editor with one clear niche ranks #1 in Nigeria. Clients rarely set reputation filters. What they test is **taste and speed**: can you pick the right 45 seconds, caption it cleanly, and deliver in two days? A beginner can show that in one well-made spec clip. Two things are still unknown: how many proposals newcomers send before their first win, and whether Nigerian location changes hire rates. Neither is visible in Upwork's data.

The risk for Harry is not lack of jobs but **getting stuck at the bottom**. $2.50–$10 clips and $3/hr retainers are real and common, and AI clippers keep pushing simple clipping prices down. The way out is the same one the $10K+ Nigerians used: take a few tiny paid tests to earn 5-star reviews, then move quickly to **one niche, batch pricing and a repeat client**. Note too that earlier niche research in this project rated short-form video a poor fit if Harry's main strength is coding. If he chooses this niche, he should use it fully and keep the profile focused only on short-form clips.